

DEATH OF A GLACIER

WYO FILM FESTIVAL
SHERIDAN • WYOMING
2026 OFFICIAL SELECTION

A FILM BY ETHAN C. PARRISH, PH.D.

High in the Bolivian Andes, the scientists who study the disappearing glaciers, alongside the community whose water depends on their meltwater, confront what is being lost.

SPECIFICATIONS

RUNTIME	16:46
FORMAT	Documentary Short
YEAR	2026
ASPECT RATIO	2.35 : 1
LANGUAGE	Spanish & English with subtitles
COUNTRY	USA / Bolivia

PRESS · SALES · BOOKING

Ethan C. Parrish, Ph.D.
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00:33 · CROSSES ABOVE THE ZONGO VALLEY





01:22 · ZONGO GLACIER

02 SYNOPSIS

Glaciers are vanishing from the Bolivian Andes. As they do, so too does the water that sustains the communities below. Death of a Glacier follows a team of climate scientists and the residents of the Zongo Valley as they confront the retreat of ice that has crowned these mountains for millennia. For the families living at the foot of Huayna Potosí, the glacier is drinking water, electricity, livelihood, and memory. For the scientists, it is a record — one that now shows the ice has shrunk past its smallest size in nearly twelve thousand years.

Told largely in Spanish by the people closest to the loss, the film moves from why glaciers matter, to what the science reveals, to the harder question of what remains possible. It refuses both denial and despair, insisting that what we still do counts.

"Maybe I will be the first to have no water — because I live so high up."

DOMITILA ALAÑA LLUSCO · ZONGO VALLEY

03 STILLS



14:03 · HUAYNA POTOSÍ & THE ZONGO VALLEY



11:01 · FIELDWORK BELOW THE GLACIER



07:06 · DOMITILA ALAÑA LLUSCO



00:53 · ADRIÁN VARGAS QUISPE



05:25 · MELTWATER



Dr. Andrew Jones

CLIMATOLOGIST · UW-MADISON · LEAD SUBJECT

Andy Jones is a PhD climate scientist who studies mountain glaciers. His research gives geologic context to the rapid retreat of glaciers around the world by establishing the bounds of 'normal' glacier fluctuations, prior to rising greenhouse gases in the Industrial Era. His work has been featured in the Los Angeles Times, The Washington Post, and NPR.



Dr. Álvaro Soruco

GLACIOLOGIST · UMSA · BOLIVIAN COLLABORATOR

Álvaro Soruco is a full professor in the Geological Engineering program at the Universidad Mayor de San Andrés (UMSA) in La Paz and Bolivia's national correspondent to the World Glacier Monitoring Service. A specialist in glacial mass balance and remote sensing, he has spent his career studying the Zongo Glacier — part of a joint Bolivian-French program holding the longest continuous glaciological record in tropical South America, running since 1991. His research quantifies how the retreating ice is reshaping the water supply for the communities of La Paz and El Alto.



Yasmeen Orellana-Salazar

PH.D. STUDENT · UW-MADISON

Yasmeen Orellana-Salazar is a Chilean geologist and Ph.D. student at the University of Wisconsin–Madison. Her research reconstructs how glaciers around volcanoes in the southern Chilean Andes have responded to climate change over time, combining remote fieldwork with laboratory analysis and climate modeling. She's especially drawn to how environmental change reshapes both landscapes and the communities that depend on them — glaciers as water source and cultural touchstone alike. Beyond research, she's passionate about science communication and helping communities connect with the geological history of the places they call home.



Matías Romero

PH.D. CANDIDATE · UW-MADISON

Matías Romero is an Argentine geologist and Ph.D. candidate at the University of Wisconsin–Madison. He studies how glaciers and ice sheets have evolved over thousands of years in response to changes in climate and the environment. His research explores the interactions among climate, ice masses, and Earth's surface to better understand how landscapes have evolved through time. His work provides important context for interpreting today's rapidly changing polar and mountain environments and for improving projections of future cryosphere change. Outside of research, Matías enjoys spending time outdoors and exploring the landscapes he studies. Through his work, he hopes to foster a greater appreciation for the dynamic nature of Earth's landscapes and to raise awareness of the rapid environmental changes reshaping them today.



Domitila Alaña Llusco

MOUNTAIN GUIDE · ZONGO VALLEY

Domitila has worked in tourism near Huayna Potosí for roughly twenty years. She was one of the founders of Cholitas Escaladoras, the collective of indigenous Bolivian women mountaineers who climb in traditional dresses. A first-hand witness to the glacier's retreat across two decades of daily life on the mountain.



Adrián Vargas Quispe

MOUNTAIN GUIDE · ZONGO VALLEY

Adrián is a Zongo Valley local who has built his livelihood leading climbing parties up Huayna Potosí and other peaks in the Cordillera Real. Living at the foot of the mountain, Adrián sees the glacier's retreat not as an abstraction but as a daily reality — one with direct consequences for the water his family depends on and the landscape his clients come to climb.

05 FILMMAKER



Ethan C. Parrish, Ph.D.

DIRECTOR · PRODUCER · DP · EDITOR

Ethan is a documentary filmmaker and geoscientist based in Wenatchee, Washington. He holds a Ph.D. in geoscience from the University of Wisconsin–Madison, where his research focused on ancient hydrologic systems and the affective impact of art-integrated science education — a throughline that runs directly into his filmmaking practice. His films center on earth science and humanity's physical relationship with the planet, built around people rather than data, with the belief that complex environmental stories become accessible when they are also emotionally resonant.

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06 PRODUCTION COMPANY

Whispering River Media

Whispering River Media is the independent documentary practice of Ethan C. Parrish, Ph.D. Based in Wenatchee, Washington, Whispering River Media makes character-driven films about earth and physical science — work that illuminates the interconnectedness of humanity and the planet, pairing scientific rigor with emotional storytelling to make complex environmental stories legible to broad audiences.

01:49 · RIDGELINE, CORDILLERA REAL



A QUESTION ABOUT DEATH

Death of a Glacier began as an idea at the University of Wisconsin–Madison, inside an interdisciplinary research initiative built around a single ancient question: how do human beings make sense of death? The initiative examined mortality not at one scale but across three — the individual, the civilizational, and the geological — asking how communities recognize, mourn, and find resilience in the face of an ending. One strand of that work reached into the earth sciences, where the retreat of glaciers offered a stark new way to think about death: not of a person, but of a landscape, and perhaps of a planet.

A TWO-PART FILM

The project unfolds in two parts, each shot on a research expedition supported by the UW–Madison proglacial lab. Part one, Death of a Glacier (Iceland), released in fall 2024, is a short, lyrical meditation — an emotionally resonant entry point into the grief of a warming world. Part two, the subject of this kit, travels to the Bolivian Andes, where the science sharpens and the human stakes come into focus: glaciers that supply the water of La Paz and El Alto, now retreating past their smallest size in nearly 12,000 years. Together the two films move from elegy to inquiry — from feeling the loss to understanding it, and asking what can still be done.

WHY THIS STORY

Framing a glacier's retreat as a death changes what the films are allowed to do. It makes room for grief without surrendering to despair — and for the scientists' and community members' shared insistence that an ending is not the same as an inevitability. Death of a Glacier carries that conviction into the field: that understanding death, at every scale, is finally a way of understanding how to keep living.

SUPPORTED BY

- University of Wisconsin–Madison Proglacial Lab

12:28 · THE NEXT GENERATION, ZONGO VALLEY



DEATH OF A GLACIER



WHISPERING RIVER MEDIA

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